

■ By Stephen David

The HAL (Hindustan Aeronautics Limited) airport at Bangalore, as any frequent flyer would swear, does little to help the city's image of being India's Silicon Valley. Over 40 years old, it was built mainly as a defence establishment, but commercial flights began operating out of there sometime in the 1980s. That of course was the time when Bangalore was more known as pensioners' paradise and the number of flights that touched down and took off from the airport could be counted on one's fingers.

Today, Bangalore has the country's third busiest airport. Last year, 7.5 million passengers passed through the terminal and the daily inbound and outbound flights number nearly 300. Though there have been periodic upgradations in the last two decades, the airport is bursting at the seams.

So what better than a swank new facility on the outskirts of the city? Good idea, except that Bangaloreans don't seem very excited. "It's great to have a new airport but the infrastructure for it should have been ready a year before," says techie entrepre-

TAKING OFF:
Sivaramakrishnan
S. Iyer of BIAL with
the airport's model



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A new world class airport is scheduled to open in Bangalore early next year but its denizens are far from excited. They cite the long distance and the lack of infrastructure to make a case for the old.

neur Rajeev Ramachandra, a globe-trotter. He is just one among those tech honchos who feel that the Government should allow the existing airport to function as well.

The new Bangalore International Airport coming up in Devanahalli is 35 km away from the city. The lack of excitement boils down to just one thing: poor infrastructure, which may dissuade many passengers from taking a long and winding road to Devanahalli. As one jet hopper puts it: "It's like opening a skyscraper and finding that the elevators are not in place."

The city's rich and the influential have been asking the civil aviation

authorities to allow both airports to function simultaneously. If that happens, the agreement with the Bangalore International Airport Limited (BIAL) would become invalid. According to the agreement, no second airport can function within 150 km of Devanahalli for the next 25 years. BIAL, which is jointly owned by the Airports Authority of India (AAI) and the state Government, is behind the idea of the new project.

BIAL's Chief Executive Officer Al Brunner says the airport will be ready by April 2008 though test flights will begin three months earlier. "We have done everything possible to make this airport one of

the best in the world," he says. Captain G.R. Gopinath, the buccaneering spirit behind India's largest low-cost carrier, Air Deccan, feels a second airport is a necessity in Bangalore. His rival-turned-partner Vijay Mallya is trying to convince the Union Civil Aviation Minister Praful Patel to allow both airports to be functional simultaneously.

The annual passenger footfall at the new airport is expected to be around 6.7 million, which is expected to touch 8.5 million by 2010. But with the existing airport already handling around eight million passengers, calculations are being hastily redone to enable it handle